



Unsustainability: On the way to a different modernity

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1. the ecological crisis and the limitations of the eco-emancipatory project: For decades, activists and intellectuals have been fighting for an ecological-social transformation, but this has come up against considerable obstacles in late modern society. Despite increased consensus on the need for change, there is a sense of powerlessness and movements such as Extinction Rebellion appear helpless. Agricultural and energy transitions face acute crises, and social justice is increasingly used as an argument against ecological measures. Many citizens cannot financially afford the ecological-social ideal and are mobilized as resistance to these ideals. The discussion is shifting from the prevention of apocalyptic scenarios to an acceptance of irreversibility. Social and ecological urgency increasingly collide with securing prosperity and international competitive disadvantages. The ecological imperative seems to be taking a back seat to ideals of freedom and guarantees of prosperity. Long-term goals that could serve humanity as a whole are seen as distant and uncertain. The normative basis of eco-emancipatory movements is being questioned as it is increasingly seen as utopian.

2. crisis diagnoses and systemic unsustainability: The thesis of unsustainability relates to several levels of the Western social system. Capitalism is not primarily called into question, but the social and ecological contradictions are intensifying. Social movements and democratic institutions are proving to be inefficient for managing late modern problems. Individualized understandings of freedom collide with planetary boundaries. The normative foundations of the eco-emancipatory project, such as human rights and democracy, are in crisis as they appear insufficient for solving current problems. The contradictions between the social ideal and ecological reality are becoming insurmountable. The supposed path to a good life for all is beginning to falter. Political and social institutions are losing their ability to act. Civil society organizations appear increasingly resigned and overwhelmed. The prospect of a cosmopolitan global society appears illusory and anachronistic.

3. social divisions and new conflicts: Late modernity is characterized by growing conflicts over social participation and demarcation. Questions of belonging and exclusion are becoming increasingly relevant. The political landscape is fragmenting, while right-wing populist movements are claiming the issue of demarcation for themselves. Identity politics is being pursued more intensely from both the left and the right. The neoliberal focus on self-responsibility promotes a policy of self-optimization. Social cohesion is endangered by such dynamics. Withdrawal into the private sphere is becoming the new social standard. The neoliberal weakening of the state is proving to be an obstacle to effective socio-ecological transformation. The focus on national borders and individual freedoms makes a globally coordinated response to ecological crises more difficult. The demands for sustainability and socio-ecological justice collide with established models of prosperity.

4. political resignation and technocracy: democratic processes are increasingly perceived as ineffective and inadequate for the complex demands of late modern

society. Calls for a return to a strong, effective state are on the rise. Autocratic and technocratic forms of government are gaining acceptance as they promise efficiency and control in times of crisis. Technocratic approaches to regulation and the transfer of responsibility to non-democratic institutions are characteristic of the political landscape. Digitalization is accelerating these developments and leading to a disintegration of collective identities. Social cohesion is suffering from the fragmentation and singularization of individual lifestyles. Democracy is increasingly perceived as a problem rather than a solution. The use of artificial intelligence (AI) and algorithmic control is replacing human autonomy. Digitalization and automation are leading to a massive loss of control over political processes. People seem ready to hand over political decisions to technical systems.

5 Planetary boundaries and the Anthropocene: The concept of planetary boundaries is used as a model for socio-ecological transformation, but its normative premise is critically scrutinized. Social and economic structures designed for growth and expansion collide with these ecological limits. Achieving a "safe operating space for humanity" seems increasingly unlikely. The realistic view of a world that operates beyond planetary boundaries entails the loss of quality of life and self-determination. The demand for a radical transformation is coming up against structural obstacles. The crisis diagnoses of late modernity reveal the unsustainability of the traditional model of a collectively controlled future. A strong ideal of growth is at odds with a sustainable system. The expansion of consumption and mobility is incompatible with planetary boundaries. Ecological and social crises require a departure from traditional ideas of freedom. The attempt to guarantee sustainability through technocratic control seems paradoxical.

6 Digitalization and algorithmic rule: The digital revolution has the potential to profoundly change democracy and autonomy. AI and automation are taking over more and more decision-making processes. Social self-determination and collective responsibility are being replaced by algorithmic processes. Digitalization is reshaping the concept of the subject as autonomous decisions are increasingly automated. Critics warn of the superiority of technological systems and the displacement of human judgment. Political control and participatory decision-making are being replaced by digital processes. Autonomous technologies could challenge the traditional notion of democracy in the long term. Social norms and values are adapting to digital logic. The political and normative power of the demos is dwindling in favor of a technocratic elite. The digital transformation is alienating society from previous models of identity and autonomy.

7 Authoritarian systems and the competition with China: Authoritarian systems, especially China, are increasingly perceived as a threat to Western values. The geopolitical conflict between democratic and autocratic systems is intensifying. Western leadership is being called into question by China's technological dominance. The moral superiority of Western democracies seems doubtful in view of their own shortcomings. A narrative of systems competition conceals the internal weaknesses of Western societies. China and Russia are portrayed as a threat to democracy and human rights. In this light, the ideals of Western modernity appear less universal and sustainable. The global balance of power is shifting in favor of authoritarian models. The competition between systems highlights the internal contradictions of the Western social order. The loss of global dominance is recognized as the result of its own social logic.

8 Capitalism and its adaptability: Capitalism itself is less at the center of the crisis than the value system of Western modernity. Ecological and social demands for adaptation to the capitalist system seem unattainable. Capitalist crisis management mechanisms reinforce existing inequalities. The sustainability crisis is often only addressed superficially, while consumption and growth increase. Crises and environmental damage are seen as necessary side effects of capitalist logic. Western modernity seems incapable of developing a genuine post-capitalist

alternative. Capitalism is being transferred to the next phase, neglecting democracy and human rights. The ecological and social challenges require a rethinking of the growth paradigm. Post-capitalist visions remain limited in their power of implementation. Capitalism adapts without making fundamental structural changes.

9 Emancipatory movements and their disappointment: Social movements that wanted to promote democracy and sustainability are experiencing increasing frustration and excessive demands. Sustainability as a universal norm is proving to be unattainable. Many sustainability efforts fail due to people's individual demands and social context. The eco-emancipatory agenda is perceived as elitist and aloof. Democratization and social change are more difficult to achieve in late modernity. Movements such as Fridays for Future have raised awareness without bringing about structural change. The fight for sustainability is often dismissed as a naive utopia. The retreat into the private sphere and the rejection of social responsibility are becoming a social trend. Individualization has created new social needs, but these rarely materialize in collective projects. The attempt to politicize the ecological transformation leads to social division.

10 The third modern age and future prospects: The third modernity leads to a society of non-sustainability in which ecological and social norms recede in favor of individual freedom. Political and social institutions lose their regulatory function. Autonomy and subjectivity are increasingly perceived as burdensome. Society is moving away from the collectivist ideal of a good life for all. The status quo is defended while structural changes fail to materialize. The increase in autocratic and technocratic solutions marks a break with European modernity. The digital revolution and AI infrastructure are accepted as necessary foundations of modern life. Democracy and autonomy are being replaced by adaptation to technological systems. Western modernity is saying goodbye to its universal claims. The third modernity is characterized by uncertainties and an acceptance of unsustainability.

Underlining in the book

Location: 411

For decades, philosophers, citizens' initiatives, social movements, green parties, international NGOs, critical social scientists and many other actors have been fighting as social avant-gardes for the great transformation. But just at the moment when there seemed to be more unity than ever and when the ecological and social urgency seemed greater than ever, the eco-emancipatory project itself suddenly slipped into a deep crisis.

Location: 417

But in late modern societies, a feeling of political powerlessness and lack of influence is spreading. The optimism of civil society and the confidence of movements in their own ability to organize and shape politics are visibly weakened. The actions of groups such as Extinction Rebellion or Last Generation appear helpless - and trigger considerable backlash despite the commitment to the goal of sustainability on all sides.

Location: 423

The agricultural turnaround, energy turnaround, transport turnaround, species protection, climate targets - all of these would certainly be politically desirable, but in the face of acute crises - pandemic, inflation, war, terrorism, migration, China's claim to global power - other things seem more urgent.

Location: 429

Animal welfare, land protection and organic farming seem to be of secondary importance. In contrast, concerns about the prosperity achieved and fear of resentment from potential right-wing voters are primary.

Location: 436

The argument of social justice and participation is used everywhere. And the masses of those who simply cannot afford to pay for the eco-social agenda are pitted against the more privileged sections of society and their eco-emancipatory project.

Location: 471

After sociologists initially spoke of the "end of sustainability",^[9] they now diagnose a shift in the environmental debate away from "apocalyptic" discourse patterns that aimed to prevent major socio-ecological catastrophes, towards "post-apocalyptic" discourse patterns, which assume that it is already too late to prevent and that late-modern societies are in the process of coming to terms with the ecological catastrophe and settling into the ecological-social ruins of capitalism and the liberal world.^[10]

Location: 483

What was recently described, at least at a declaratory level, as a categorical imperative - climate protection, human rights, democracy, biodiversity, planetary boundaries, a good life for all - is now being openly questioned because it threatens prevailing concepts of freedom, jeopardizes the prosperity we have achieved and brings tangible disadvantages in international competition, while the promised benefits are long-term at best, tend to benefit distant countries and foreign people and are by no means certain anyway.

Location: 559

The basic assumption and starting point has therefore always been that people can choose, decide and control for themselves, that they are not simply at the mercy of their fate, but can shape their lives, their community and their relationship with nature themselves. The assumption is that they not only have a right to steer their own course, but also a duty to do so, especially in the face of ecological threats. In fact, the ecological crisis is elevating the responsible assumption of responsibility to a new categorical imperative.

Figure 1: Constitutive elements of the eco-emancipatory

- Criticism of domination, oppression, exploitation, instrumentalization and enslavement of man and nature; demand for self-determination, liberation from domination, development of the independence and autonomy of man and nature;
- Guarantee of inviolable dignity, universal rights, autonomy, the status recognized to man and nature as an autonomous subject;
- Superiority of diversity and difference over standardization;
- Belief in moral freedom and responsibility; trust in rationality and reason; belief in non-negotiable ecological imperatives, ecological reason and responsibility;
- Belief in the ability to shape society and the world; collective steering ability; trust in civil society self-organization and democratic self-government;
- The right to civic maturity and the ability to take collective responsibility for the community;
- Long-term and precaution as design principles; education, information and training as essential means of promoting ecological maturity and responsibility;
- Expansion of democratic participation as a means of progressive politics in this sense; self-image as the avant-garde of an ecologically, militarily and socially pacified new society;
- global social horizon and cosmopolitan perspective.

Location: 612

Against the backdrop of the supremacy of global corporations, the overwhelming dependence of Western societies on authoritarian systems and developments in the field of digital technologies and artificial intelligence, the belief in the democratic ability to shape and control things seems almost naïve. In view of the tension between the ongoing dissolution of the boundaries of widespread demands for freedom and self-realization and clearly identifiable planetary boundaries, a "good life for all" is probably an impossibility. And in view of the new global systemic competition between China and the West as well as the problems of transnational and international institutions such as the EU or the UN, the vision of a cosmopolitan global society seems illusory and strangely anachronistic.

Location: 692

I developed the thesis that in advanced modern societies, democratic institutions and procedures can be described as "simulative" insofar as they articulate and make tangible democratic values to which modern citizens and societies feel deeply committed and which are an indispensable part of their identity and self-image, but which are also perceived as increasingly unsuitable for solving the problems of today's societies with the necessary efficiency and effectiveness, and which no longer do justice to today's understanding of individual freedom and self-determination.

Location: 737

Is it actually conceivable that the EEP and the model of Western modernity as a whole could be exhausted once³⁷ without this being accompanied by the end of humanity or the world?

Location: 741

The abandonment of the idea of the autonomous subject - as the central norm of social theory - which Luhmann had already vehemently called for, but which was still an

unbearable provocation at the time, has now become mainstream in large parts of the social sciences. "In the broader discussion in the humanities and cultural studies," write Block and Dickel, "decidedly post-humanist interpretations have been emerging for some years, which affirm the end of the autonomous subject or have accepted it as a realistic possibility." [27]

Location: 758

Moving beyond the narrower focus on the crisis of the EEP, the question now is whether it is actually conceivable that Western modernity and its fundamental norms of freedom, the self-determined subject, human rights, democracy, the open society, etc. will one day survive.

Location: 775

However, the possible exhaustion of their project, its becoming obsolete and its emancipatory abandonment, could not (and did not want to) be imagined by the pioneers of ÖEP 40. Not to this day. From their perspective, i.e. i.e. within their normative horizon, this possibility was and is literally unthinkable. This possible becoming obsolete is, probably not least for this reason, always thought of as the end, the apocalypse, the downfall of humanity.

Location: 785

In fact, talk of the demise of humanity - despite all theoretical possibilities and the now comprehensively documented destruction of biophysical systems - is to a certain extent the left-wing activist counterpart to the right-wing populist denial of global warming and the sustainability crisis. "End or change" and "Business as usual is not an option" are the TINA ("there is no alternative") of the emancipatory climate movement and critical environmental sociology. What this emancipatory-critical TINA thinking and the thinking of climate change deniers have in common is that they both ignore a scenario that is in fact the most realistic, but which would cause the world to collapse from their respective perspectives and is therefore intolerable. However, "there is an alternative" and "business as usual" are certainly an option - but this means that late-modern societies (have to) separate themselves from the norms and social self-descriptions that Western societies as a whole, and the champions of the ÖEP and the SÖT in particular, have so far loudly and identity-formingly carried before them.

Location: 804

When Niklas Luhmann stated in the 1980s that functionally differentiated societies were hardly in a position to overcome their ecological crisis due to the incompatibility of their competing system logics,[31] this was an unbearable provocation for emancipatory environmental movements and critical sociology. However, Luhmann made an important contribution to understanding the lasting unsustainability of modern societies and the obstacles to a SÖT.

Location: 843

I have drawn attention to the completely new constellation after the end of humanity, which will be illuminated in the following chapters. This space and this constellation only become visible when we look beyond the activist dualism of "end or turn" and when we leave the normativity of this threat and mobilization scenario behind us.

Location: 898

Overall, this book pursues a threefold objective: firstly, it aims to contribute to consolidating the socio-theoretical foundations of environmental and sustainability sociology. This is because much of the relevant literature is still primarily concerned with shoulds, wishes, hopes and appeals. But we can now look back on more than five decades of such hopes and appeals, and the limits of this approach have become abundantly clear. In view of the worsening crises, the constant renewal of such hopeful narratives is becoming increasingly doubtful. In normative terms, too, this approach is now untenable. After all, narratives of hope that are known to be unfounded and to come to nothing are likely to fuel experiences of disappointment and frustration, thereby fueling social conflicts that are becoming increasingly difficult to overcome.

Location: 929

40] In fact, this book deals not only with a double, but a triple untenability: a) that of the established arrangements of the society of unsustainability, b) that of the ÖEP and its activist narratives and c) that of critical sociology and its normativity. All three are, to return

to Eugen Roth's verse, "quite untenable - unfortunately" in late modernity.

Location: 940

With the climate emergency, which the Fridays for Future movement raised public awareness of more than ever in 2019, the Covid-19 pandemic since March 2020, the significant rise in inflation since mid-2021 and the war in Ukraine, the phenomenon of unsustainability suddenly became very real. Far beyond an ecological understanding, unsustainability became a shocking and inescapable unsustainability. Practically overnight, everyday things that were taken for granted actually became unsustainable and - unlike the many things that had long been known to be unsustainable - were actually restricted or suspended, whether through the collapse of certain systems (such as international supply chains) or through political regulation (e.g. shopping, celebration, travel or import restrictions).

Location: 966

When growth reaches its limits, but demands and expectations continue to rise, the question of who can continue to participate in what, where the boundaries should be drawn and who and what must be excluded becomes virulent. The changed constellation has now made it unmistakably clear: not less, but more is more - and in case of doubt, also safer. And: if fewer are allowed to participate, more remains for those entitled! The right-wing populists have most obviously made the issue of drawing borders and exclusion their political brand essence with their campaigns against "immigration into the social systems", migration-related competition for housing, in the labor market or for daycare places.

Location: 972

The politics of demarcation and exclusion 56 has many faces: it appears as intensified identity politics from the left (cancel culture) and the right (nationalisms, conspiracy myths), as the neoliberal doctrine of self-responsibility, as the rediscovery of state regulation in the name of climate protection, as right-wing populist politics against migrants and minorities or as fundamentalist rigorism in religious communities.

Location: 1,006

In modern distraction and distraction societies, everything is actually geared towards ensuring that moments of reflection and such concern do not occur at all. However, where the strategies of the accelerated entertainment and anaesthetic industry are not effective, it is becoming ominously clear that something very fundamental is happening that goes far beyond the previous discussion of post-democracy, descent society or the Great Regression.

Location: 1,033

The established economy and way of life is incompatible with ambitious ecological and social standards, fundamentally dependent on the import of raw materials, energy and consumer goods from countries that categorically reject basic Western values and rights, and on the export of Western products to countries that do the same.

Location: 1,061

The optimism of civil society is turning into resignation and radicalism. Today, hope in the new politics of the social movements seems no less exhausted than trust in the institutions of traditional politics.

Location: 1,072

There is little to suggest that the fundamental contradiction between the commitment to ecology and human rights and the defense of Western prosperity and lifestyle can be resolved.

Location: 1,077

This loss of perspective and control is traumatic for modern Western societies, for whose self-image the ability to shape and control and an open future have always been essential. In late modernity, it now also affects those who previously saw themselves as the pioneers, the avant-garde, the enlightened and knowledgeable.

Location: 1,086

The decades-long effort to gain a clear understanding and judgment, to get involved and take responsibility, leads to excessive demands, disillusionment and exhaustion.[55] This is also a borderline experience, an abyss, a state of emergency.

Location: 1,142

From a socio-psychological perspective, these hopeful narratives are an expression of a refusal to face up to the specificity of the late modern constellation. They are a kind of "self-illusion"[64] that evades the crucial question of why the current crisis should fulfill what has not yet been fulfilled since the beginning of the environmental movement. From a social science perspective, where exactly and in what respect have the parameters changed right now in a way that gives reason to believe that the eco-emancipatory vision could now become reality?

Location: 1,155

Rather, the recent crises have impressively illustrated how the boundaries of what is socially acceptable and tolerable are shifting ever further in favor of securing the status quo - and how society's ability to imagine real alternatives to the established order and its logic is being eroded ever further.

Location: 1,172

Against the backdrop of the pandemic and war, the narrative of the "crisis as an opportunity" has reached its limits; it is exhausted. This is also a borderline experience, a very decisive one that late modern societies are currently experiencing.

Location: 1,175

On the contrary, the recent crises have actually reinforced and strengthened the logic of acceleration, growth, competition, inequality and exclusion. This is because the public debt burden increases with every crisis, as does the pressure to subsequently "grow out of debt". This reduces the scope for socio-ecological transformation and leaves little room for post-growth and degrowth in particular.

Location: 1,189

The ability and willingness of late modern societies to transform is significantly impaired by the interplay of various factors: These societies have long since found themselves in a maelstrom in which they can hardly plan and steer for the future, but are instead strongly fixated on the present and are primarily concerned with getting at least halfway under control of the immediate consequences of the increasingly rapid succession of crises. In doing so, they have to weigh up ever more carefully whether it is worth investing the available funds in long-term projects for socio-ecological transformation or in short-term measures to combat the acute consequences of disasters.

Location: 1,197

A socio-ecological transformation that ensures a good life for all would require a massive reduction in consumption, a restriction of demands and expectations in practically all areas of life and a renunciation of many habits, far beyond what today's citizens perceive as an unnecessary luxury - and by no means just for a relatively small upper class. Because "even with only a minimally comfortable lifestyle, consumers in the Global North far exceed all target values for per capita emissions"[65].

Location: 1,204

The triumph of neoliberalism in particular has solidified understandings of freedom and self-realization that regard any political regulation as unacceptable interference in the private sphere. This project to remove boundaries has placed enormous (over) demands on planetary borders and at the same time considerably reduced the potential for collective self-limitation.

Location: 1,212

However, the possibilities of the depoliticized market are no less limited, as ecologically and socially sustainable prices would no longer be affordable for significant sections of society and would be directly linked to a significant reduction in living standards and social exclusion. This brings social organizations, right-wing populists and many other actors onto the scene.

Location: 1,217

However, limiting, shrinking and doing without are taboo; an absolute reduction in the need for mobility, electronics, housing or energy, for example, is not up for debate beyond very marginalized groups.

Location: 1,218

For decades, social movements and scientific experts have focused on decentralized, participatory, consensus-oriented and flexible policy approaches as the most promising path to a sustainability transformation.

Location: 1,222

However, it is now clear that the possibilities of the new, decentralized, participatory politics have been considerably overestimated. Many climate activists and sustainability researchers are now once again calling for a strong, capable state, but this has been permanently weakened by neoliberal ideology.

Location: 1,236

The diversity and complexity of value preferences makes it difficult to define problems by consensus and set stable priorities. The competition between the different logics of the social functional systems that have to deal with the problems in practice is a major obstacle to coordinated and consistent problem solving.

Location: 1,243

And finally, overcoming the various more limited crises is also increasingly overshadowed by the new major geopolitical conflict between China and the West and the competition between liberal-democratic and autocratic-authoritarian systems for global supremacy.

Location: 1,250

It will indeed be a tight squeeze for a suspension of the logic of growth, competition, exploitation and efficiency, for an absolute limitation and reduction of demands, expectations and needs and for a decisive social redistribution that would enable a good life for all. However, precisely these parameters would be indispensable for a socio-ecological transformation towards sustainability, which would have to go far beyond today's decarbonization efforts. Accordingly, such a transformation is not to be expected for structural reasons.

Location: 1,257

The common appeals that "we" must now "act together, immediately and decisively" in the face of the current crisis, that it is now time to "finally move from talk to action", are primarily of a confessional, experiential and reassuring nature. They serve moral and psychological needs, but are based on a completely inadequate understanding of late modern societies.

Location: 1,310

In the ecological dimension of the ÖEP, for example, the belief that the ecological issue could be a unifying, collectivizing issue for humanity is proving to be an illusion in view of the latest developments.

Location: 1,318

"To speak of nature is not to sign a peace treaty," wrote Bruno Latour soberingly correctly. "Nature does not unite, it divides."

Location: 1,325

This also proves the belief in a rational and moral, collective self-limitation in favor of a "good life for all" to be an illusion.

Location: 1,334

The conviction that more democracy necessarily leads to more sustainability is also untenable.

Location: 1,338

Instead, there is much to suggest that political pressure for more democratic participation has always been a key driver of the fossil fuel growth economy and the continued externalization of social and environmental costs.

Location: 1,349

Instead, it is becoming increasingly obvious that the eco-emancipatory movements have not only been unable to solve the socio-ecological crisis, but have actually exacerbated it themselves in various ways:

Location: 1,355

Due to their highly developed understanding of freedom and self-realization, and their tendency to belong to educated and high-income milieus, citizens with a high level of sustainability awareness often have an above-average resource-intensive lifestyle and a large ecological footprint.

Location: 1,366

This means that late modern societies are at a critical and highly unsettling point. Although the sustainability crisis is accelerating in all its dimensions, the peace movement, civil society, ecological, grassroots democratic alternative project appears conspicuously exhausted.

Location: 1,402

Today's specifically late-modern disillusionment is not primarily based on the disillusioned promise of classical, industrial modernity, but on the secondary optimism of progress of the participatory and eco-emancipatory revolution.

Location: 1,468

However, the diagnosis of the untenability of certain assumptions and beliefs of critical (sustainability) sociology and the ÖEP in no way implies a call for anti-democratic, anti-egalitarian, anti-ecological or anti-emancipatory values. Rather, it is about recognizing that various assumptions and beliefs of the EEP have proven to be empirically false in late modern societies: Not only do they not lead to a solution, they sometimes even exacerbate the problem. These beliefs and the political struggle to realize them have obviously not led late modern societies to a socially and ecologically pacified society, but - of course neither as the sole cause nor consciously and intentionally - to the edge of an abyss and to the threshold of a new modernity that leaves the basic values of the previous one behind or spells them out in a completely new way.

Location: 1,503

Polanyi was convinced that the idea of a self-regulating market was a "crass utopia" and that the "philosophy of liberalism" was destructive and that a pure market society "could not exist over long periods of time" without "destroying the human and natural substance of society".[109] He described the dynamics of marketization as a "diabolical mechanism". The "inevitable result" of liberal philosophy was initially the comprehensive destabilization of society and then the "victory of fascism", which meant the "complete annihilation of

freedom".[110] However, Polanyi also developed the thesis that the socially destructive forces of liberal capitalism could mobilize counter-forces that would once again contain the market and the individual striving for freedom.

Location: 1,608

107 The crisis of globalized financial capitalism therefore by no means heralds the end of capitalism. Although the end of democratic capitalism has long been in sight, capitalism survives even without democracy and human rights[129] because in capitalist realism it no longer requires legitimization, especially not democratic legitimization.

Location: 1,613

In Germany, trade policy towards the People's Republic of China or energy procurement policy towards Russia, Qatar and other authoritarian states illustrate that economic interests and securing prosperity always take precedence over democracy and human rights.

Location: 1,615

A final crisis of capitalism, on the other hand, is just as little in sight as a politically promising alternative to capitalism, be it as an economic system, as an "institutionalized social order" or as a "way of life".

Location: 1,623

"Fundamental and comprehensive criticism of capitalist modernity", write Carolin Amlinger and Oliver Nachtwey, is "barely audible - and if it is, then with practically no chance of practical implementation".

Location: 1,662

It is not capitalism that is in crisis today and threatening to collapse - it is perhaps merely going through a new adjustment crisis. Rather, in late modern society, the system of norms underlying the crisis theory and the visions of post-capitalist society is losing its power.

Location: 1,734

The great appeal of the concept of planetary boundaries lies in this combination of concrete instructions for action or limitation and absolute urgency. The attempt by Earth system science to define a "safe operating space for humanity" within such boundaries could provide precisely what ecological movements have so far urgently lacked.[146] It ties in with earlier attempts to derive from ecological issues what Marxist social critique has always sought but has never been able to provide : compelling reference norms, imperatives and guidelines for a fundamental social transformation.

Location: 1,740

However, the hope that the concept of planetary boundaries could provide a significant impetus for socio-ecological transformation is questionable in that the supposedly scientifically determinable boundaries actually always have a social normative core. As with the functional critique of capitalism, it is also true in the case of planetary boundaries that we may not want to live in a society and world that exceeds these boundaries because this contradicts established norms and expectations, but not that we could not live in such a world.

Location: 1,746

If planetary boundaries are exceeded, then there will certainly no longer be a good life for everyone; devastating catastrophes, great suffering and the increasing loss of the ability to control and steer will be among the unavoidable consequences.

Location: 1,808

Because the complexity of the circumstances is too high and the volatility of the situations too great, because the perceptions of problems and priorities are too diverse and because there are no institutions for a coordinated, long-term and effective global domestic policy, the Earth System Governance project has little prospect of success.

Location: 1,848

Liberal democracy, perhaps the greatest political achievement of modern societies, is in decline. Late modern societies are becoming increasingly difficult to control politically, especially democratically. Their crises, conflicts and disasters - and not just ecological ones - are indeed increasingly ungovernable.

Location: 1,854

The sustainability crisis, climate change, the migration problem, the Covid pandemic and the war in Ukraine illustrate a fundamental and structural overstretching of the state.

Location: 1,912

But in fact, in late modern societies - even if the vociferous criticism of democratic deficits and the many demands for genuine democracy seem to suggest otherwise - the claim to democratic self-determination is often willingly abandoned and ceded, not least because of the burdens, obligations and responsibilities that necessarily accompany democratic self-government. The permanent call for commitment and responsibility and the associated moral pressure are widely perceived as excessive demands and overload.

Location: 1,920

While the emancipatory movements were still determined to try out and practice new forms of collective, democratic self-government, the defensive retreat into the private sphere is becoming the norm in the face of the multiple crisis - "in the ruins of the liberal world"[174]. Political leadership and binding decisions, which can obviously no longer be made democratically at the required speed and with the desired reliability, are expected from the state and academia.

Location: 1,927

Instead, the "longing for technocratic depoliticization" and the "successive normalization of social risks" are becoming dominant in late modern society. The "protective technocracy" is the "vanishing point of the social contract".

Location: 1,953

The question would therefore be how to ensure that further democratization efforts do not exacerbate the now known side effects. Moreover, new democratization initiatives are never guided by absolute, supposedly unchangeable criteria of true democracy, but always by precisely those ideas and understandings of freedom, self-determination and a good life that are dominant in a given society at the time. And in late modern societies, there is little reason to assume that this could lead to more equality, justice, ecology, human rights, etc.

Location: 1,973

The specifically late-modern characteristic is that democratic claims are willingly abandoned and relinquished and autocratic-authoritarian forms of governance are accepted as necessary and even demanded.

Location: 1,992

In terms of democracy, the digital revolution has indeed contributed to networking. At the same time, however, it is destroying social cohesion and causing political culture to disintegrate. On the one hand, real people are networking, but at the same time, digitalization is promoting acceleration and dispersion beyond a level that is conducive and tolerable for democracy. In particular, it is leading to the disintegration of shared social reality and the public sphere.

Location: 2,002

Digitalization is radicalizing what had long before emerged as the individualization and singularization of modern societies[182]: the decomposition of collective actors and identities into individualized subjects, which in turn differentiate themselves into fragmented, fluid identities and have less and less claim to be consistent and stable in themselves. In terms of realpolitik, the digitally multiplied society with its fragmented, virtualized and dynamized realities and inhabitants is becoming increasingly difficult to govern.

Location: 2,019

Although the high vulnerability of digital systems is increasingly becoming a fundamental threat to late-modern societies, the digital 140 revolution is being promoted as a priority project by practically all political players. Even green parties see it as a positive contribution to solving the multiple sustainability crisis - perhaps because autonomy, the right to shape and the ability to control can only be articulated and experienced in late modernity by pushing for their own abolition. This leads "almost inevitably to an ontological reconfiguration" of late modern societies, "in which human subjects become objects" of observation, management and control by artificial intelligence.

Location: 2,039

Such efforts to achieve "good" digitalization and AI are directly comparable to the well-known debate about "good" and "bad" economic growth, the distinction between market instruments that "promote sustainability" and those that "harm sustainability" or the hopes for a "good" Anthropocene. In these areas too, however, the fight for political oversight, greater transparency, accountability, democratic openness and links to ethical and ecological standards has repeatedly failed. These efforts have never led to a structural correction and reversal of the logic and order of unsustainability. Accordingly, the hope for democratic control of the digital revolution and artificial intelligence appears to have little foundation. After all, democratic design, management and control do not follow any categorical guidelines, but only the prevailing, context-dependent norms of the demos (however defined).

Location: 2,064

Furthermore, the hopes and narratives of political control and containment of digitalization also completely misjudge the categorical leap of the digital revolution from the modernist project of participation, inclusion and involvement of natural persons understood as autonomous subjects to their total capture, translation and dissolution into binary coded data. In other words, the narrative of political control overlooks or denies what is actually revolutionary about the digital revolution. For in the digital society, natural persons understood as autonomous subjects, to whom reason and morality and an inviolable dignity

are attributed according to modernist tradition, are no longer the relevant point of reference; instead, artificial intelligence controls, manages and utilizes data sets that supposedly depict natural people and their communities, but which are radically detached from them and categorically different. To the extent that the digital revolution not only transfers autonomy from the human, moral, rational subject to self-learning machines, but instead of natural people, machine-generated data sets are increasingly becoming the point of reference for interactions that are in turn controlled by algorithms, digitalization is indeed a revolution. Just like the Anthropocene, this revolution completely undermines the basic principles, fundamental values and self-image of European modernity.

Location: 2,088

If there was ever a possibility and a window of opportunity for modernist containment of the digital revolution, then it has long since closed. Even critics of digitalization have to admit: "It is not clear how we can imagine the development and use of machine learning for the benefit of all beyond manipulative recommendation algorithms and decision automation." In fact, the idea of a "good" AI society "that spells out the great importance of these technologies on the one hand and the choices they offer on the other in such a way that the challenges they present can be dealt with democratically" is probably illusory.

Location: 2,096

Attempts at politicization and democratic control will therefore do just as little to slow down the digital revolution as the further unfolding of the Anthropocene. Rather, late modern society and its citizens will in all likelihood come to terms with these far-reaching revolutions by adapting their modernist evaluation norms and standards.

Location: 2,100

Thus, the digital revolution is not taking place automatically, but - like neoliberal globalization in its day - is being deliberately pursued as a political project. However, its operators are themselves driven, and their project not only cannot be stopped, but can only be controlled and governed to a very limited extent - only accelerated.

Location: 2,111

Against the backdrop of individual and collective overload, loss of control and ungovernability, at the point where emancipatory movements themselves are losing their normative orientation and political self-confidence, autonomy and sovereignty are now being transferred to algorithms and artificial intelligence. Accordingly, they are perceived less and less as a threat, but rather as salvation, an enabling condition and indispensable infrastructure.

Location: 2,117

And if the "singularization" of late modern individuals, identities and lifestyles is a consequence and achievement of the emancipatory revolution,[191] then it is precisely this development, i.e. emancipation itself, that makes the digital infrastructure necessary - on the one hand to articulate and develop this singularity and, on the other, to recapture it and make it governable. Accordingly, emancipatory values are of little use as a normative basis for criticizing and regulating the digital revolution.

Location: 2,126

As an evidence-based technology, AI is more powerful and more legitimate than any democratic negotiation or decision.

Location: 2,129

"The hope of being able to avoid fatal mistakes with the help of algorithms," writes Jeanette Hofmann correctly, "may indeed prove to be a temptation that is difficult to resist."

Location: 2,136

However, the inevitable "price for a general recognition of algorithmic judgments" is the "gradual [...] fading of autonomy as a democratic norm" and an "indispensable basic prerequisite for democratic coexistence".

Location: 2,143

To a certain extent, the digital revolution completes the replacement of the autonomous subject as the modernist central norm.

Location: 2,151

While those who warn of the uncontrollable catastrophes of climate change and the Anthropocene fear the biophysical end of humanity, the digital revolution signifies the cultural-historical end of humanity, of civilization, in the sense of the end of the supposedly universally valid ideals that form the normative core of European-Western modernity.

Location: 2,172

The narrative of systemic competition between the authoritarian People's Republic and the free, democratic world takes up the old rhetoric of the Cold War and at the same time updates the even older narrative of the downfall of the West.[199] It suggests that the other modernity already described in various aspects in the previous sections will become an Asian, a Chinese modernity.

Location: 2,190

The fear of China's rise thus combines essential elements of the other crisis discourses described above: the increased superiority of capital in state capitalism, the autocratic-authoritarian turn, total digital surveillance, the suppression of democracy, freedom and human rights, concerns about global warming and the threat to the West's self-image of economic, political and moral superiority - the radical loss of status of the West compared to its previous service provider. However, the common narrative of the new systemic competition and the threat posed to the West by China is easily recognizable as an ideological mobilization and defence narrative that primarily aims to confirm and secure the West's claim to moral superiority and a global leadership role.

Location: 2,255

Talk of competition between freedom and authoritarianism, democracy and dictatorship implies a moral obligation to side with freedom and democracy and thus against China and Russia. There are certainly good reasons for the latter, but it would be wrong to believe that the autocratic-authoritarian turn in Western countries has its main cause in China or Russia. And accordingly, it is also wrong to think that it will be beneficial for democracy and freedom to now increasingly support the project of the free West.

Location: 2,261

The five crises of late modernity discussed above and identified from different perspectives have a common core. Ultimately, they all diagnose violations of the central norm of European-Western modernity, i.e. the idea of the autonomous subject. And the demands for transformation associated with the respective diagnoses of crisis are always aimed at defending or restoring precisely this norm. In late modernity, however, it is becoming clear that it is not capitalism that is untenable at the present time, but the normative narrative of its crisis and collapse and of the liberated post-capitalist society. Crossing planetary boundaries does not mean the demise of humanity, but the full and irreversible implementation of a geological turning point; and this in turn, the Anthropocene, means the disintegration of the world view and way of thinking on which the previous diagnoses of the ecological crisis and the ecological-emancipatory project of a socio-ecological transformation are based. The post-democratic and autocratic-authoritarian turn is not a relapse or loss per se; rather, democracy in late modernity is increasingly perceived as dysfunctional and lacking legitimacy. Alternative methods of decision-making and governance appear superior and desirable. The digital revolution and artificial intelligence are perceived less and less as a fundamental threat, but rather as an indispensable prerequisite and infrastructure for a good life, self-development and public administration. The disintegration of European-Western self-descriptions and the loss of the global leadership role can hardly be convincingly presented as the consequence of the threat from an external enemy (China), but rather result more and more clearly from the implementation of the internal logic of European-Western modernity.

Location: 2,284

It is correct to assume that the multiple crisis is a systemic crisis. However, contrary to popular belief, the system that is falling apart is not capitalism (neither as an economic system nor as a social order in a broader sense), but the value system of European-Western modernity.

Location: 2,295

Ultimately, unsustainability refers to the entire value system of European-Western modernity and the social institutions and arrangements on which these values are based.

Location: 2,305

Figure 2: Major transformations in late modernity

Perspektive	Krisenwahrnehmung	geforderte/erhoffte Transformation	faktische Transformation	faktische Unhaltbarkeit	Entproblematisierung
ökonomisch	Zusammenbruch des Kapitalismus	befreite Postwachstumsgesellschaft	aktualisierende Anpassung des Kapitalismus	Referenznormen der hergebrachten Kapitalismuskritik	Kapitalismus ohne Demokratie und Menschenrechte
ökologisch; erdsystemwissenschaftlich	Kollaps biophysischer Systeme; Gefahr für Bewohnbarkeit des Planeten und Überleben der Menschheit	sozialökologische Transformation; Earth-System Governance; kollektive Selbstbegrenzung	neues erdgeschichtliches Zeitalter; Gesellschaft der Nicht-Nachhaltigkeit; ökologische Unregierbarkeit; neuer Naturzustand	Dualismen der Moderne; ökopolitische Imperative; <i>Prinzip Verantwortung</i>	Ende der Natur; Verletzung der modernistischen Normen des ÖEP
politisch	Bedrohung der Demokratie	Verteidigung und Stärkung (Demokratisierung) der Demokratie	autokratisch-autoritäre Wende	politische Freiheit, demokratische Selbstbestimmung	autokratisch-illiberale Postdemokratie
technologisch	autoritäre Überwachungsgesellschaft	<i>Reclaim autonomy</i> ; autonomie- und demokratiekonforme Digitalisierung	analoge Welt in digitale Datensätze; algorithmengesteuerte, Gesellschaft	Vorstellung des Subjekts von Freiheit, Würde und universalen Rechten als zentraler Referenzpunkt	Autonomie der Maschine; Herrschaft systemischer Imperative
geopolitisch; geokulturell	Untergang des Abendlandes	Verteidigung von Demokratie und Menschenrechten (sog. westlichen Werten)	Verschiebung der internationalen Machtordnung	europäische Aufklärung; westliche Führungsrolle	Ungleichheit, Exklusion; Entzivilisierung, Barbarei

Location: 2,390

The significance of the pandemic and the war in Ukraine, which can hardly be overestimated, is now much clearer: it was or is due to the fact that they have not only highlighted the unsustainability, but also the lack of alternatives and non-negotiability of so-called normality, i.e. the order of unsustainability. This order is defended at all costs, "whatever the cost".

Location: 2,398

It is precisely the uncompromising defense of so-called normality that accelerates the development of the next society and the other modernity. Both emerge precisely not through the controlled transformation to a desired alternative, but as a side effect of the ironclad defense of the status quo - as well as through the implementation of emancipatory logic itself.

Location: 2,460

This new scepticism towards sociological theorizing concerns in particular the forms of modernization theory that declared ideals to be universally valid, which emerged from specifically European traditions of thought, and assumed that all societies worldwide would follow a more or less uniform path of development - linear, irreversible, deterministic - towards the realization of these ideals.

Location: 2,473

This form of modernization theory is an ideological instrument to justify Western fantasies of superiority and an interventionist-colonial policy of development control and transfer of institutions[221].

Location: 2,506

In contrast to the older modernization theories, the newer approaches have largely abandoned the idea of linear progress for the better, as well as the idea of a largely uniform development path for all societies, on the basis of which Western industrial societies can be regarded as pioneers, others as their successors and still others as laggards.

Location: 2,520

"The offensive attitude of progress is [...] being replaced by a more defensive orientation towards prevention, resilience and loss minimization."[230]

Location: 2,581

Beck's concepts of "victory crisis", "failure to succeed", "self-run" and "metamorphosis" (of modernity) are particularly suitable for explaining the double unsustainability of late modern society and the ÖEP as an unavoidable dialectical consequence of their own logic. With these terms, Beck moved away from the fable that liberation from capitalism would be the solution and back to Horkheimer and Adorno's thesis of the dialectic of enlightenment, that the problem - insoluble - lies in the project of enlightenment itself.

Location: 2,586

For Beck, individualization and the ecological side effects of industrial modernity were two equally constitutive aspects of the risk society.

Location: 2,668

And the more the binding force of traditional structures and norms loosened, the more the compulsion for social conformity that prevailed in the first modern era was replaced by the social compulsion for independence and originality. Beck therefore described individualization as a "paradoxical social structure"[244].

Location: 2,750

In line with the identified deficits of the first modernity, the substantive agenda of the second modernity for Beck primarily included (a) the ecological restructuring of industrial society, which was a prerequisite for the realization of the new ideas of subjectivity as well as for the intrinsic value attributed to nature by parts of the movements, (b) the full democratization of politics and society, which were still perceived as very incompletely democratic, and (c) the development of a cosmopolitan world society, which was a necessary prerequisite both for solving ecological problems and with a view to realizing universalist norms of freedom and self-determination.

Location: 2,865

Beck was convinced that the risk society would inevitably and automatically drift beyond the nation state into a cosmopolitan world society, because the ideas of autonomy and subjectivity that had become hegemonic in the silent revolution were universal values and the problems of the first modern age could not be solved by the nation state.

Location: 2,895

Thus, in Beck's eyes, ecological remoralization, the reinvention of the political and the cosmopolitan moment add up to a transformative dynamic, to a self-running modernization triggered by the risk constellation, which transforms the modernity that has so far been halved into a new, a second modernity, in which social institutions finally fully correspond to the ideals of modernity.

Location: 2,933

From today's perspective, Beck's hopes appear "overly optimistic" - especially in the simplicity in which they have been presented here so far.

Location: 3,004

An ecological restructuring of industrial society has so far taken place at best in rudimentary form and only in the sense of an ecological modernization that does not change the logic and grammar of the first modernity, but rather reinforces it. It has been confirmed that the topic of climate and the ecological restructuring of society strongly moralize, politicize and polarize. But contrary to Beck's expectations, "refusal to do ecological service" has indeed become an option, indeed a fairly widespread one.

Location: 3,012

In fact, in view of the new moralization and polarization as well as the diversity of incompatible values and interests in society, a state of eco-political self-paralysis and ungovernability has long since established itself.

Location: 3,031

The invention of the political did not lead to the empowerment of citizens vis-à-vis the elites, but to the expansion of the (political) privileges of an already privileged middle class. It did not lead to the hoped-for democratization of democracy, but to the further distortion of political representation.[305] The NSB and their new, experimental politics were ultimately not the pioneers of a socio-ecological transformation, but often only pioneers of the gentrification of inner cities and social distinction.[306] Their value orientations, lifestyles and activism in turn became the ignition for massive counter-movements of anti-ecological rebellion.

Location: 3,065

There is no doubt that individualization has created new needs for community and identity; in late modernity, however, these are not satisfied in a global risk community, but rather in neo-communities and communicative bubbles that cultivate specific narratives of meaning without having to reflect the complexity of real people, lifeworlds and social conditions. In contrast, the idea of identifying with the cosmopolitan community was far too demanding, abstract and overwhelming.

Location: 3,173

If ecology movements hoped to use nature "as a yardstick against its destruction", said Beck, they would be guilty of a "naturalistic misunderstanding"[327] and of "forgetting society".[328] And reflexive modernization is itself increasingly exhausting all supposedly objective norms, thus further weakening its own prospects of success. Meanwhile, cultural norms and the cultural willingness to perceive²²⁹ are becoming increasingly important.

Location: 3,211

The EEP thus demanded both the liberation from everything that claimed to be natural and unchangeable and the subordination to categorical ecological necessities.

Location: 3,242

Figure 3: Internal contradictions of the ÖEP

Das ökoemanzipatorische Paradox	
radikale Kritik der Moderne	Verteidigung und Weiterführung der Moderne
Ehrfurcht, Staunen der Natur gegenüber	Kontroll-, Gestaltungs- und Steuerungsanspruch
Grenzsetzung/Begrenzung und Unterordnung unter Natur als Regelgebende zugunsten der Autonomie/ Integrität der Natur	Grenzüberschreitung/ Entgrenzung und Befreiung vom Natürlichen zugunsten der Autonomie des Subjekts
kategorische ökologische Imperative (Pflicht)	radikale Selbstbestimmung (Freiheit)
Objektivität, biophysische Fakten	Subjektivität, Normen der Wahrnehmung
Grenzen, Begrenzung, Unterordnung im Namen des Allgemeinen	Befreiung, Grenzüberschreitung im Namen der individuellen Besonderung
Selbstbestimmung des kollektiven Subjekts	Selbstbestimmung des individuellen Subjekts
Autonomie als Selbstbestimmung nach Maßgabe einer übergeordneten Vernunft	Autonomie als Selbstverwirklichung nach Maßgabe individueller Einzigartigkeit
Demokratisierung als Ermächtigung der Zivilgesellschaft der mündigen Bürgerinnen und Bürger	Demokratisierung als Ermächtigung heterogener Individualagenden
Gleichheit, Gerechtigkeit, umfassende Inklusion, universelle Werte und Rechte	Besonderheit, Unterscheidbarkeit, Individualität, Diversität, authentische Selbstverwirklichung
Langfristigkeit, Stabilität, Verlässlichkeit, Prinzipientreue, Regelbindung, Verantwortung	Spontaneität, Offenheit, Ungebundenheit, Flexibilität, alternative Rationalitäten

Location: 3,286

What was understood and presented as a project for humanity and the realization of universal rights thus became increasingly recognizable as the project of a bourgeois-liberal elite. And this is precisely why in late modernity, in which the narrative of universal rights and the good life for all is becoming increasingly untenable, it is also becoming a crystallization point for massive divisions and conflicts.

Location: 3,388

Three moderns and two transitions

erste Moderne		zweite Moderne		dritte Moderne
fordistische Industriegesellschaft	stille Revolution	postindustrielle Gesellschaft, Risikogesellschaft	Spätmoderne	Gesellschaft der Nicht-Nachhaltigkeit
Aufhebung vormoderne Sicherheiten; Anspruch auf Gestaltbarkeit und Selbstbestimmung		Aufhebung der falschen Sicherheiten der ersten Moderne; Neuformulierung des Anspruchs auf Gestaltbarkeit und Selbstbestimmung		Aufhebung der entzauberten Glaubenssätze und Sicherheiten der zweiten Moderne/des ÖEP

Location: 3,437

In the third modernity, the project of rational, collective control and designability in favor of a good life for all within ecological limits and eternal peace in a cosmopolitan society becomes a complete fiction. Instead, the society of non-sustainability is defended by all means - including exclusion and marginalization.

Location: 3,482

Although the new politics of the second modernity no longer relied on the old actors and structures, i.e. on what Beck described as the "basic institutions" of the first modernity, it resolutely adhered to the basic principles, in particular the ideal of the autonomous subject, conceived in the Kantian sense as collective and determined by reason. In this respect, the second modernity actually meant a renewal and extension of the first modernity, not a radical break.

Figure 5: Modernity as the age of autonomy

erste Moderne		zweite Moderne		dritte Moderne
Autonomie des Subjekts als gesetzlich verankerter Anspruch; nur eingeschränkt praxiswirksam	stille Revolution	Autonomie des Subjekts als breite realpolitische Forderung; praktische Umsetzung im ÖEP	Spätmoderne	jenseits des kantischen Subjekts
Autonomie des Subjekts; analoge Moderne				Autonomie der KI; digitale Moderne

Location: 3,510

However, the idea of the identical subject, i.e. the subject as the originator and bearer of an identity - consistent, stable, principled - is individualized (Beck), singularized (Reckwitz) and flexibilized or dynamized (Bauman, Rosa). The idea of the autonomous subject, i.e. the subject as sovereign, as the bearer of a free will and as a responsible decision-maker, increasingly appears to be an excessive demand and a burden. Both in the area of individual and collective decision-making and shaping, the decision-making competence and responsibility still emphatically demanded by the NSB and the ÖEP is being delegated to service providers that appear suitable - populist leaders, expert councils, technocratic elites and, crucially, artificial intelligence. The traditional understanding of the autonomous subject is thus being overcome in an emancipatory way: The third modernity is a modernity beyond the Kantian subject.

Location: 3,553

According to Horkheimer and Adorno's dialectic of enlightenment, the term "dialectic" aims to explain how a progressive, emancipatory agenda can unintentionally and unnoticed turn into its opposite: for Horkheimer and Adorno, enlightenment into barbarism;^[356] in the present case, ecologization into unsustainability or democratization into the autocratic-authoritarian turn.

Location: 3,558

If we follow Hegel's understanding, "dialectic" aims rather to explain how the internal, antithetically and indissolubly opposed contradictions of a constellation lead to its untenability and disintegration, which in turn pave the way for the emergence of a new constellation, a synthesis in which the contradictions that have now been overcome are suspended in a double sense. Dialectics here is the constructive tension between contradictions, from whose conflict something new emerges: here another, a third modernity.

Location: 3,661

However, protecting the integrity of nature and the environment under the auspices of the autonomy of the self or the subject - which only constitutes and asserts itself through its emancipation from nature and naturalness^[371] - is a contradiction in terms: the integrity of nature requires the limitation and subordination of the subject; the autonomy of the subject, on the other hand, means transgressing supposedly natural boundaries and dominating nature.

Location: 3,722

Following the experience that there was not yet a sufficiently integrating, motivating and politically enforceable normative basis for the greening of industrial society, and that the greening issue - especially in its anti-growth and anti-capitalist variant - triggered fears,

insecurity and defensive reactions in large parts of society, the sustainability paradigm explicitly aimed to depoliticize the debate and place practical measures on a scientific basis.

Location: 3,760

While it has always focused on the supposedly non-political and objective, the sustainability paradigm has always deliberately neglected this subjective aspect and left it to its own devices in a liberal manner. And so, firstly, the hegemony of the sustainability concept has led to a situation in which comprehensive knowledge about ecological changes, their causes, their interactions and their consequences is available, as well as a wide range of technologies that could be helpful in dealing with them, but it is now surprising to note that there is a lack of political will to apply this knowledge and technology in a targeted, determined and consistent manner - because this would require a normative definition that is fundamentally alien to the sustainability paradigm. Secondly, the focus on the objective and the neglect of the subjective have created a protected niche in which the liberal values of individualistic self-determination and self-realization have been able to develop undisturbed in contrast to the values of restriction, subordination, self-discipline and duty, which are no less important for the ecological project.

Location: 3,786

In fact, the scientific nature of the sustainability paradigm increasingly disconnected the eco-political debate from the concrete lives and experiences of citizens, marginalizing those whose values and protests had originally put the ecological issue on the political agenda and diametrically contradicting the emancipatory claim to political self-determination and self-design that had once brought the New Social Movements into being. The increasingly differentiated science and the ever new, often contradictory research results undermined trust in science and, as an unavoidable side effect, systematically paved the way for a scepticism of science strategically fomented by interested parties.

Location: 3,794

"Who believes in a risk and why", Beck wrote ten years before these terms became popular in the wake of Donald Trump's presidency, is becoming "more important than the experts' elaborate probability scenarios".[383] "We are experiencing an invasion of culture into politics", he emphasized; the "risk community is splitting along the lines of who shares which definitions of risk".

Location: 3,820

In this respect, the paradigm of sustainability has, in a sense, provided an afterthought: time bought[387] for a dying illusion.

Location: 3,825

The concept of sustainability has never actually been about structural transformation and turning away from the established logic of non-sustainability, but has always been primarily about the stabilization and extension of capitalism and the crisis-ridden Western modern age as a whole.

Location: 3,989

Older ideals of self-discipline, acceptance of authority and subordination to social norms have been replaced by ideals of unfolding, articulating and experiencing one's own authentic self.

Location: 4,069

Emanzipation			
Befreiung aus/von...		Verwirklichung des...	
Abgrenzung, Selbstunterscheidung, Selbstsetzung	Selbstbehauptung, Abwehr von, Kampf gegen	Entwicklung von Fähigkeiten und Infrastrukturen	Zielvorstellung, Utopie, regulatives Ideal

While the theoretical claim to freedom, self-determination and authentic self-realization in late modern societies is more developed than ever before, de facto not only has control over

the social conditions of authentic self-determination and self-realization evaporated,[416] but also any notion of something truly authentic and essential that could provide identity and would not be purely coincidental and interchangeable. Reckwitz accordingly diagnoses a "crisis of self-realization", Rosa the "reversal of the experience of the world from approximate omnipotence to paralyzing powerlessness", and Amlinger and Nachtwey describe the syndrome of "offended freedom".

Location: 4,075

"Early modernity," Bauman wrote well before all of them, "uprooted people in order to reclassify them." In late modernity, on the other hand, uprooting is permanent: "At the end of the road, these permanently uprooted individuals have no prospect of reintegration." In particular, this development means that "the concept of citizenship is gradually dissolving"[418].

Location: 4,080

297Ecopolitically, this further development of prevailing understandings of autonomy, subjectivity, identity and emancipation leads straight into the society of unsustainability, the imperial way of life and life at the expense of others,[419] because it establishes understandings of self-determination and self-realization that are highly individualistic and fixated on the present, heavily dependent on the consumer goods and experience industry and resource-intensive, and which also deliberately aim for uniqueness and exclusivity.

Location: 4,095

Many authors see neoliberalism and the logic of capitalism as a whole as the driving force behind this development, which is largely undisputed in the social sciences.

Location: 4,104

Neoliberalism thus appropriates, colonizes and alienates the concept of autonomy in a way that makes genuine autonomy impossible. And the pressure on people to place their entire lives under the categorical imperative of self-optimization and self-marketing at all times results in a comprehensive exhaustion syndrome.

Location: 4,109

Figure 7: Historicization of the emancipatory project of liberation

	Befreiung aus/von...		Verwirklichung des...		
	Selbstunterscheidung von	Kampf gegen	Erwerb/Entfaltung von	Hoffnung auf	
kantischer Rationalismus	Tier, Instinkt	Aberglaube, Irrationalität, Bequemlichkeit, Faulheit	Mündigkeit, Fähigkeit zum Vernunftgebrauch	kollektives Subjekt, Weltgesellschaft, ewiger Friede	philosophische Moderne
klassische Industriegesellschaft	kapitalistische Machtverhältnisse, falsches Bewusstsein, Verblendungszusammenhang	Ideologie, Unterdrückung, Ausbeutung, Kapitaleigner, Kapitalismus	Klassenbewusstsein, Entfremdungsbewusstsein, politische Organisationsfähigkeit	Klassensubjekt, sozialistische Persönlichkeit/neuer Mensch, befreite internationale Gesellschaft	erste Moderne
postindustrielle Gesellschaft	Tradition, Standardisierung, Massenkultur	gesellschaftliche Normen, vorbestimmte soziale Rollen	individuelle Fähigkeiten der Selbstbestimmung und Selbstverwirklichung	individuelle Persönlichkeit, authentische Selbstverwirklichung	zweite Moderne
Gesellschaft der Nicht-Nachhaltigkeit	Gesellschaft, modernistische Verständnisse von Autonomie und Subjektivität	kategorische Imperative, einengende Verpflichtungen, Begriffe des Allgemeinwohls	Spontaneität, Potenziale, alternative Formen von Vernunft, Wettbewerbsfähigkeit	Singularität, optimierte Selbstverwirklichung/Selbsterfahrung, das unternehmerische Selbst	dritte Moderne

Location: 4,165

In fact, however, the problem lies not only in the complicity of some emancipatory currents with the neoliberal agenda, but rather in the fact that the continuous updating, the reflexive modernization of prevailing understandings of autonomy and emancipation corrodes any notion of a general, authentic and essential.

Location: 4,177

In the hope of still finding warmth and orientation there - something essential, an essence or even "sacred basic principles" of their identity - climate activists, advocates of wokeness, activists of cancel culture, critical social scientists and right-wing identitarian movements all equally strive to return to the smouldering remnants of their respective "tribal fires".[427] And the illiberal, exclusionary and authoritarianism that is often characteristic of identity-seeking movements on both the left and the right of the ideological spectrum in late modernity can essentially be explained by the attempt to counter the depletion of the general and essential and the crisis of self-realization with a new moral fundamentalism.

Location: 4,223

In late modernity, autonomy, subjectivity and emancipation have as little to do with the imperatives of reason as they do with the bourgeois idea of maturity or the romantic idea of authenticity.

Location: 4,251

What late modern societies glorify as "our freedom", "our values" and "our lifestyle" is considered an emancipatory achievement, despite its unsustainability and unsustainability. It is defended by "emancipatory" movements which, according to the conventional understanding of emancipation, can only be described as regressive, i.e. as exclusive, anti-democratic and anti-ecological.

Location: 4,317

Manow sees the central problem in the democratizing erosion of the principle of representation. Liberal representative democracy, he says with recourse to Jacques Rancière, John Dunne and others, was never democratic in the sense of the sovereignty of the people, but was always an elite rule based on the principle of "repression through representation".[448] The people were excluded by installing procedures for their representation, and only this exclusion made the supposed rule of the people stable. However, democracy became increasingly inclusive. More and more social groups and minorities fought for ever more far-reaching participation rights. And this constant expansion of participation successively eroded the stabilizing principle of representation. The current problem of democracy therefore lies in "the constant expansion of this participation, it is the problem of the democratization of democracy". "In essence," writes Manow, "the thesis is that the [...] expansion of opportunities for participation, described as the democratization of democracy, appears to threaten the institutional 314 functional conditions of democracy."

Location: 4,327

Strategies of depoliticization through the transfer of political decisions and responsibilities to non-majoritarian institutions within and beyond the nation state are an attempt to counter this threat and stabilize the overburdened democracy. However, such strategies would once again mean de-democratization, which would ultimately only further fuel the discontent of the excluded and their struggle for the democratization of democracy. According to Manow, this fight for direct participation is particularly destabilizing due to the "obsolescence of mediating bodies" such as political parties and the "loss of their filter function".

Location: 4,370

The eco-emancipatory movements thus pursued precisely what Manow describes today as the "crucial" problem of late modern democracies and blames above all on right-wing populism.[454] With their project of democratizing democracy, they pursued a structural change in the political public sphere, attempted to wrest political discourse from the control of the established parties and media, and fought to redefine the political agenda in their own terms.

Location: 4,387

Democratic self-determination should thus reverse the filter function of established institutions, filter out the individualistic and economic irrationality that has dominated up to now and give full weight to the responsible, reasonable and mature. The democratization of democracy should, in the words of Ulrich Beck, give full weight to the "sacred basic principles" of modernity - not least because participatory and deliberative democracy would have an enlightening and educational effect on citizens.

Location: 4,402

Ecological reason, responsibility and maturity, subordination to general principles or a commitment to the common good play at most a casual role in late modernity - in the neo-Biedermeier retreat to the personal.

Location: 4,419

This multiple dysfunctionality of democracy[457] has led to a comprehensive loss of trust in late modernity, which has long since affected not only the existing democratic institutions, but also faith in democracy as a whole. And the democratization of democracy pursued by the eco-emancipatory movements has clearly contributed to this.

Location: 4,431

Democratic achievements such as environmental impact assessments or public participation procedures become an additional obstacle for projects such as the expansion of renewable energies.

Location: 4,482

With regard to the democratic pillar, too, this confirms that the ÖEP is not simply failing because capitalism and its elites are blocking and suppressing it, but that it is essentially breaking down due to its own logic - due to too much politicization and participation.

Location: 4,544

The effect of the threefold dialectic is that it is not the "sacred basic principles" that reshape the unsustainable basic institutions, but the reflexively modernized basic principles that stabilize the now "canonized" basic institutions of unsustainability.

Location: 4,548

From the perspective of the ÖEP, this shift in precedent and this repoliticization appear traumatic.

Location: 4,621

As indicated above, anyone who wants to open up and understand late modernity must therefore neither blacken pessimism nor embellish optimism, but must separate themselves from both.[475] Beck defended himself against the doomsday scenarios of older, mostly conservative cultural criticism, "because in lamenting the end of the world it conceals the end of its own unreflected world certainties".

Location: 4,665

The late modern concepts of freedom, subjectivity and self-realization are not supported or justified here. Biophysical realities, changes and causal relationships are in no way disputed or relativized. It is also expressly not the aim to exonerate the structures, elites and power relations of capitalism. Rather, the aim is to grasp the traumatic nature of the unintended side effects of the ÖEP, which is the distinguishing feature of late modernity.

Location: 4,701

From the perspective of the second modernity and the ÖEP, the observable metamorphosis of late modern societies is admittedly an abyss. In terms of social theory, however, the new modernity that is emerging in outline is actually different above all.

Location: 4,705

Beyond sociological curiosity and the attempt to conceptualize and understand the late modern turn of the era, however, my interest also lies in breaking out of the spiral of conflict in which late modern societies are trapped. A considerable threat in late modernity lies not only in the rapid destruction of biophysical systems, but also in the fact that all norms for their evaluation are more clearly recognizable than ever as ultimately unfounded fundamentalisms and contingent. This is precisely what makes late modernity so uncertain, irritable, polarizing and explosive. Radical, self-referential fundamentalism takes the place of rational reasoning and justification, but is notoriously hypersensitive and precarious. In this constellation, the climate issue and the EEP also become a question of faith, a cultural struggle, a radical divisive issue and a harsh, ideologized confrontation. With its aforementioned defensive reflexes and its sociologically hardly justifiable hopeful narratives, sociology itself is driving this spiral of conflict: The constant renewal of narratives of liberation, hope and solutions generates ever new potentials for disappointment and frustration[482].

Location: 4,807

Social inequality and exclusion are just as unavoidable a part of the new modern age as increasingly frequent crises and disasters. This is a reality that late modern citizens are trying to come to terms with. While the goal of the second modernity was great transformation and correction, the goal of the third modernity is to optimize resilience.

Location: 4,866

Horkheimer and Adorno already wrote: "It is part of the hopeless state of affairs that even the most honest reformer [...] reinforces the power of the existing, which he wants to break,

by adopting the entrenched category apparatus and the bad philosophy behind it."

Location: 4,890

But late modern societies look back on more than five decades of such hopeful narratives, and the limitations of this approach are abundantly clear. In the face of worsening crises, their constant renewal becomes increasingly cruel.[502] Their supposed optimism ultimately produces frustration, because what is presented as a transformation strategy actually prolongs and deepens unsustainability.

Location: 4,900

Instead of presenting further transformation books that are largely disconnected from the reality of late modern societies, the aim should be to develop a sociology of non-sustainability.

Location: 4,923

In view of its not least emancipatory causes, there is no reason to assume that 362political education could change the order of unsustainability - inequality, exclusion, division, polarization, demarcation, exclusion, deportation - and slow down or even avert the social development trends that it opposes. However, it does open up discursive spaces in which the commitment to the values that are increasingly being adopted in late modernity - inclusion in a good life for all within ecological limits, ethics of togetherness, democracy, responsibility - can continue to be cultivated, while the opposite logic is deliberately promoted in real society.

Location: 4,933

Critical sociology, transformative sustainability literature and political education thus suffer equally from the syndrome that in late modernity and the third modernity the distinction between critical and affirmative, progressive and regressive, transformative and stabilizing is becoming increasingly difficult.